

The

Steel-Drivin' Man



A Tale of John Henry

*Adapted from American folklore
and the ballads of the
Chesapeake & Ohio Railway*

*“This old hammer killed John Henry —
but it won't kill me. Won't kill me. Won't kill me.”*

— Traditional hammer song

Chapter I

The Boy and the Hammer

They say John Henry came into the world on a black night in the 1840s, born to a woman who had known the long road from one Virginia plantation to another. The cabin was small and low, with a single window stuffed with rags against the cold, and a hearth that glowed orange on the hard-packed dirt floor. Outside, the cicadas hushed. Inside, the midwife wiped her hands on her apron and laid the baby in his mother's arms.

He was a big child, broad-chested even then, with hands already too large for his small wrists. When the firelight caught his eyes, they looked older than they had any right to be. The story goes that the baby reached up and laid one tiny palm against his mother's cheek, and that he spoke. Folks who tell it that way swear he said:

“A hammer'll be the death of me.”

Most folks, of course, will tell you babies don't talk. But every legend has to start somewhere, and John Henry's started early.

What is certain is this: he grew. He grew the way a young hickory grows when no one is shading it. By twelve he could lift a barrel of cider clean off the wagon bed; by sixteen he could outwork men twice his age in the cotton fields and the sawmill yards. After Emancipation, when he stood among the freedmen looking down a road that was suddenly his to walk, he chose the road that ran toward the railroad camps.

A man with arms like John Henry's could earn good money there. A dollar and a quarter a day, sometimes more, swinging a hammer for the iron horse. And if there was a small voice in the back of his head whispering about a hammer being the death of him, well, John Henry had learned a long time ago not to listen to voices that told him to stop.



Chapter II

Polly Ann

She was small, was Polly Ann, no taller than the middle button of John Henry's shirt. But she had a laugh that could fill a clearing and a temper that could empty one. She wore her hair tied up in a yellow kerchief, and she walked like a woman who had never once doubted where she was going.

They met at a brush-arbor church somewhere in the Carolinas, on a Sunday so hot the pine boards smelled like turpentine. John Henry was passing through with a road crew. Polly Ann was singing in the front row, her voice slipping easy above the others, and when John Henry sang back from the rear bench, the whole congregation turned to look at the big man with the deep, quiet voice.

After the service, he walked her home along a red dirt road. He did not speak much. He did not need to. By the time they reached her gate, Polly Ann had already decided.

They were married before the next full moon and went on together to the next camp, and the next, following the iron rails as the rails followed the rivers. Polly Ann cooked, washed, mended, raised a baby boy who looked just like his daddy, and sang to keep the lonesome out of the cabin doors. She also, when the need arose, drove steel.

For there is one part of the legend most folks forget: when John Henry took sick one autumn, Polly Ann picked up his hammer, walked out to the cut, and rang it down on the steel as steady as any man on the line. She drove that drill nine feet straight through hard rock before sundown, and the foreman, who had been ready to laugh, took off his hat instead. *That woman*, he is supposed to have said, *is half the reason her husband is the steel-drivin' man he is.*



Chapter III

The Big Bend Tunnel

In the early 1870s, the country was stitching itself back together with iron thread. The war was over. The South lay in pieces. And the Chesapeake and Ohio Railway was pushing west out of Tidewater Virginia, climbing into the Allegheny Mountains, hunting for the Ohio River the way a thirsty man hunts a spring.

In a little hollow of West Virginia called Talcott, the line ran up against Big Bend Mountain — a great green hump of rock around which the Greenbrier River wound itself in a seven-mile lazy loop. Engineers, sweating in their wool waistcoats, pointed at the mountain and said the river could keep its loop; the railroad would go *through*. They drew a tunnel on the map, a mile and a quarter long, straight as a rifle shot.

Building it was another matter.

In February of 1870, the work began. Eight hundred men, most of them Black, many of them lately freed and many leased out as convict labor from the state penitentiary, came down off the wagons with their bedrolls and their tin cups and looked up at Big Bend Mountain. They built shanty rows along the riverbank. They built a cookhouse, a smithy, a paymaster's shed. They built a graveyard, too, because the foremen knew what was coming even if the men did not.

The mountain was made of red shale. When you cut into it, the rock crumbled in your hand like stale cornbread. When you blasted into it, the dust came out the tunnel mouth in a long red breath, and a man who breathed too much of that breath would find, a year or two later, that his lungs had turned to stone.

The work went like this: a *shaker* knelt or crouched at the rock face and held a long steel drill bit, eight-sided, taller than he was. The *steel driver* stood behind him with a ten-pound hammer and brought it down on the head of that drill, swing after swing, while the shaker rotated the bit a quarter turn between every blow and gave it a shake to clear the dust from the hole. Hour after hour. Inch by inch. Hammer, turn, hammer, turn. When the hole was deep enough — three or four feet, sometimes more — the powderman came up with his black powder and his fuse, and everybody ran.

The blast would shake the mountain. The smoke would roll. The mules would scream. And then the men would walk back into the tunnel with their wheelbarrows to clear the broken rock

and start the next hole.

It was the kind of work that killed a man slow if it didn't kill him fast.

John Henry came to Big Bend in the spring of 1871, with Polly Ann and the baby in a wagon behind him. He stepped down off that wagon, looked up at the mountain, looked at the dark mouth of the tunnel where the lamp-light flickered, and rolled up his sleeves.

The foreman that day was a tall white man called Captain Tommy, who wore a stained collar and a watch on a brass chain and squinted at every new arrival as if measuring him for a pine box. When he saw John Henry — six and a half feet of muscle, hands the size of skillets, eyes calm as still water — Captain Tommy whistled low through his teeth.

“Boy,” he said, “you ever drove steel?”

“Yes, sir,” John Henry said.

“How long can you swing?”

“Long as you got rock.”

Captain Tommy laughed for the first time in a month. “Get him a hammer,” he told the foreman. “Get him *two* hammers.”

That was how John Henry came to the Big Bend Tunnel.



Chapter IV

The Salesman's Wager

The shaker assigned to John Henry was a slim young man named Li'l Bill. Li'l Bill was twenty years old and weighed maybe a hundred and thirty pounds soaking wet, but he had the steadiest hands in the whole crew. He had to. A shaker with shaky hands does not stay a shaker for long; he becomes a man with one hand, or no hands, or no head.

The first morning the two of them worked together, John Henry made the rock ring like a bell. He swung the ten-pound hammer in long, easy arcs, his big shoulders rolling, his breath even, the head of the hammer coming down so true that Li'l Bill could feel the drill bite deeper without ever feeling a tremor in his wrists. By dinnertime they had driven a hole eight feet deep. By supertime they had driven another. The other crews stopped to watch them, and the watching was its own kind of prayer.

After a week, men were coming up the line just to *see* him. After a month, the song was already starting:

*John Henry was a steel-drivin' man, Lord, Lord —
John Henry was a steel-drivin' man.*

Polly Ann sang it while she scrubbed shirts in the river. The baby clapped his little hands.

It was sometime that summer when the salesman came.

He arrived on the noon train in a checked suit and a flat-brimmed hat, with a leather valise full of papers and a smile that was a little too long for his face. He was selling a *steam drill* — a great hissing, snorting iron contraption that worked by piston and steam and could, he claimed, drill rock faster than any ten men on Earth. He had sold one to the Lewis Tunnel down the line. He wanted to sell one to Captain Tommy, too.

Captain Tommy stood in the cookhouse doorway, chewing the end of an unlit cigar, and listened to the pitch. Around him, half the crew gathered to listen as well. Behind them, John Henry stood with his arms folded, the great hammer leaning against his thigh.

“This here machine,” said the salesman, slapping a brochure with the back of his hand, “will do the work of fifteen men. *Fifteen*. And it don't get tired. It don't ask for wages. It don't quit on you Saturday night.”

A muttering went through the men. They were rough men, plain men. Some of them had only just gotten free of one master. They knew very well what it meant when a thing did not ask for wages.

John Henry did not mutter. He cleared his throat.

“Mister,” he said, and the cookhouse went quiet because John Henry seldom spoke loud, “this here machine of yours — would you put it up against a man?”

The salesman blinked. “Beg pardon?”

“A *contest*,” said John Henry. “Your machine, my hammers. Whichever drives the deepest hole, that’s the winner.”

The salesman started to laugh and then stopped, because Captain Tommy was not laughing. Captain Tommy was looking at John Henry with a strange, narrow expression, as if he were watching a man walk out onto a frozen pond.

“John Henry,” he said, “you don’t have to —”

“I want to,” John Henry said.

The bargain was struck right there, by the cookhouse door, with the cicadas singing in the trees and the smell of cornbread coming off the stove. If the steam drill won, Captain Tommy would buy a fleet of them, and the steel drivers could go look for other work. If John Henry won, the machine would go back where it came from, at least for a while.

That night, Polly Ann was quiet for a long time over the wash basin. Then she said, “John Henry, you don’t have to prove nothing to anyone.”

“I ain’t proving it to anyone,” he said.

“To who, then?”

He thought about that for a while, watching the lamp flicker on the cabin wall. “To myself,” he said at last. “And to the boy.”

She did not argue. She had known him too long to argue. She only laid out his good shirt for the morning and put two extra biscuits in his lunch tin.



Chapter V

The Contest

The day of the contest was a Saturday in high summer, and the heat lay on Talcott like a wet wool blanket. Word had spread for fifty miles. Farmers came in from up the Greenbrier with their wives and children. The C&O sent men down from Hinton with notebooks. Even the saloon at the bottom of the holler closed for the day, because every drinking man in the county was already out at the tunnel mouth.

The steam drill was set up on a wheeled carriage at the east heading. It hissed and trembled and shot little bursts of white steam from its joints, like an animal scenting blood. Beside it stood the salesman in his checked suit, holding a stopwatch.

A few yards down the rock face, John Henry stood at his own station. He had stripped off his shirt. His chest was wide and dark and slick with sweat already, though he had not yet swung. In each hand he held a hammer — *two* hammers, ten pounds apiece, where any other man would have used one. Li'l Bill knelt before him with a pair of drills, one in each hand, his face calm as a Sunday morning.

Polly Ann stood at the back of the crowd with the baby on her hip. She did not call out. She did not wave. She just watched.

Captain Tommy raised his arm.

“Gentlemen,” he said, “begin.”

The steam drill *roared*. It threw itself against the rock with a clatter like an iron mill collapsing, spitting dust and steam in a great gray cloud. The salesman shouted encouragement at it, though it could not hear him.

John Henry brought down his right hand. Then his left. Then his right.

Ring.

Ring.

Ring.

The hammers fell in perfect time, one and then the other, each blow striking the head of the drill with a sound like a great bronze bell. Li'l Bill turned the bits between strokes, his hands a blur. The dust rose around them in a red plume. John Henry's eyes were half-closed. He was not

watching the rock. He was somewhere far inside himself, where the only thing in the world was the swing of the hammer and the breath in his lungs.

The first hour passed. Both holes were deep.

The second hour passed. The steam drill faltered once; its bit caught and bent, and the salesman cursed and replaced it. John Henry never broke rhythm.

The third hour. The fourth. The water boys ran to and fro with dippers. Polly Ann sent up biscuits and cold tea, and John Henry took the tea without slowing — drank it in two swallows between strokes — and handed back the cup, and brought down the next hammer.

By late afternoon his arms were running with blood from the shoulders down, where the tendons had begun to tear under the skin. He did not slow. He did not speak. The crowd had gone quiet, the way crowds will when they realize they are watching something they will tell their grandchildren about.

The sun started to slip behind Big Bend Mountain.

Captain Tommy raised his arm again.

“Time!” he shouted.

The steam drill coughed and went still. John Henry brought his hammers down once, twice more — he could not seem to stop — and then he let them fall to the ground, where they hit the rock with a sound like two final notes.

The men with measuring sticks crawled into the holes.

The steam drill had driven nine feet.

John Henry had driven *fourteen*.

A great roar went up from the crowd. Hats flew into the air. The water boys danced. The salesman stood with his stopwatch in his hand, looking at the dial as if it had personally betrayed him.

John Henry did not roar. He stood very still, his chest rising and falling, his face calm. Polly Ann pushed through the crowd to him, the baby still on her hip, and she put her free hand against his cheek the way she had on that red dirt road in the Carolinas, years and years before.

“You won, John Henry,” she said softly.

He smiled at her. It was a small, tired smile, but it was a real one.

“I beat it, Polly Ann.”

“You sure did, baby.”

“I beat it down.”

And then John Henry's knees gave way, and he sat down hard on the broken rock, with his two hammers beside him, and he leaned his head against his wife's shoulder. He breathed in. He breathed out.

His heart, which had been hammering inside his great chest for thirty years to the rhythm of a working man's life, gave one more long beat. And then it was still.

*He laid down his hammer and he died, Lord, Lord —
he laid down his hammer and he died.*



Chapter VI

The Echo

They buried John Henry — some say near the tunnel, some say behind a whitewashed prison wall down in Richmond, some say in a place that nobody living can point to anymore. The truth of it is that nobody is sure where he lies. That is the way with legends. The body becomes the country, and the country becomes the song.

The Big Bend Tunnel was finished on the twelfth of September, 1872. The first locomotive that rolled through it sounded its whistle long and loud, and old men along the Greenbrier River swore the mountain answered back — that under the chuff of the engine, you could still hear, faintly, the ring of two hammers in perfect time.

The C&O bought no fleet of steam drills that summer. The salesman packed up his checked suit and went away. In time, of course, the machines came anyway. They always do. But for a little while, in one tunnel, in one mountain, in one moment, a man held the line.

Polly Ann raised the boy on her own. She sang to him every night. By the time he was old enough to swing a hammer, the song his mother sang him was already being sung in cotton fields in Alabama and lumber camps in Oregon and longshore wharves in New Orleans, and men who had never seen Big Bend Mountain were beating out its rhythm on the steel.

*This old hammer killed John Henry —
but it won't kill me. Won't kill me. Won't kill me.*

You can still go to Talcott, West Virginia, and stand in the long grass at the eastern mouth of the tunnel. There is a statue there now, of a big bare-chested man with a hammer in each hand. The river makes its lazy seven-mile loop around the mountain just as it always did. The trains do not run through the tunnel anymore — they have a newer one, a few yards off — but if you put your hand on the cool stone of the old archway, on a hot afternoon in July, some folks say you can still feel a faint, slow pulse, deep in the rock.

Like a heartbeat.

Like a hammer.

Like a man.



Lord, Lord — he was a steel-drivin' man.



*Set in Times Roman.
Adapted from the folklore of John Henry,
the ballads of the Chesapeake & Ohio Railway,
and the Great Bend Tunnel of Talcott, West Virginia.*